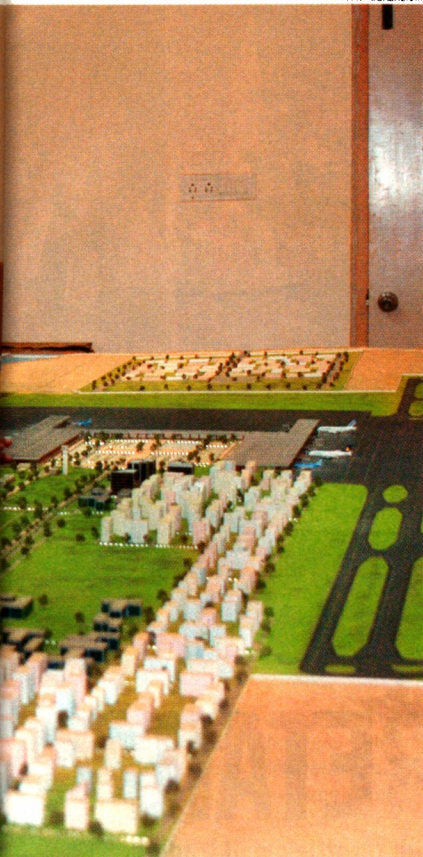


H K HAJASHKAR



FASTEN YOUR SEAT BELTS

- Last year 7.5 million passengers passed through the Bangalore airport. The daily inbound and outbound flights number nearly 300. It is the third largest airport in domestic air traffic and fourth internationally.
- This figure is expected to rise to 11 million by next year. The Bangalore airport has a 37 per cent share in low fare airlines' market.
- Though the new airport will be ready by early 2008, the proposed 21.2-km six-lane expressway to the airport will not be complete by then.
- The city's powerful tech honchos and other businessmen are lobbying with the Centre to allow both airports to function simultaneously.
- But the private sector owners of the new airport cite contract clauses to ensure only one functions at a time.

B K RAMESH



BRAKES ON: Reaching the airport would be a flyer's nightmare

11 million passengers next year itself. The city airport has a 37 per cent share in the low fare airlines' market.

The problem, however, lies in the connectivity. It is not clear how the impending passengers will reach the new airport. The Delhi Metro team

has proposed to the state Government a train service from MG Road, in the heart of the city, to the Devanahalli airport, which will cover the distance in 23 minutes. "We are waiting for a detailed project report now," says the state Infrastructure Minister B. Sriramulu. The Railways has also chipped in with its bit and is

planning to construct a terminal at Devanahalli to run a shuttle from the Cantonment railway station in the city to the new airport.

But so far, there has been all talk and little action. "The Government should work on the logistics on a war footing. Maybe HAL airport should serve the domestic and low cost routes for another two years, while the road and rail links are established. That way both sides will benefit," says N.R. Mohanty, former chairman of HAL.

However, it is no mean task building a road to the airport. A six-lane expressway, which was to connect the new airport with the outer ring road and was expected to ease traffic from the busy NH-7 (Bangalore-Hyderabad), has encountered a number of delays. This Rs 482-crore mega project has been stalled due to vehement protests by the residents of nearby areas like Challakere, Vaddarapalya and Dodda Gubbi, among others. The chances of this 21.2-km road being completed even by next year seem grim. This road was expected to cater to at least 22,000 passengers, heading towards the Devanahalli airport daily. Add to that number the relatives and friends, who will patch along, the number can go up by five times or more. Till then, the state Government has decided to spruce up the other state highways and the minor connecting roads to take the pressure off NH-7.

At its current pace of construction, the Devanahalli airport will be ready in time. The question that the promoters are asking is: will the others involved keep their deadlines? As an airport in the private sector, it just cannot afford to bleed. The state Government Principal Secretary of Infrastructure, V.P. Baligar, who also serves on the BIAL board, says a day's delay in Devanahalli airport project costs them Rs 1.76 lakh. Everyone involved is keeping their fingers crossed and hoping that the infrastructure back-ups in time. If not, the days of Bangalore's frequent flyers, who will soon have to switch to the new airport, will have to start a little early to beat the chaos on the roads to the airport. ■